They raised some other issues related to discrimination against Sikhs. These included reduction of recruitment of Sikhs to the Indian Army, harassment of Sikh farmers in the Terai region of Uttar Pradesh and denial of second-language status to the Punjabi language in the states of Himachal, Haryana and Rajasthan.

The Akalis were not convinced with the facts and figures presented at the meeting to counter their allegations. Soon afterwards, they announced that the talks had failed and that they would organize a mass protest at the site on the date of inauguration of work on the Sutlej–Yamuna Link Canal by Indira Gandhi.

Armed and dangerous

Despite the ban imposed by the Punjab government on possession of arms, not only was Bhindranwale openly moving around in Punjab with a posse of armed men, he also visited Delhi in the first week of April 1982 at the invitation of Santokh Singh, president of the Congress-controlled DSGMC. Bhindranwale was accompanied by two busloads of his followers, who were seen in the capital with armed men sitting on the roof of a bus.

On that day I was to go to Connaught Place for some work. My car was stopped at Baba Kharak Singh Marg by the police as a procession led by Bhindranwale had to be made way for. To ensure that nobody missed Bhindranwale's presence in the bus, it was being announced on loudspeaker that the public could have darshan of 'Sant Bhindranwale Ji' who was sitting on the left side front seat of the bus and was clearly visible to bystanders. The procession then proceeded towards the inner circle of Connaught Place. Given his notoriety, it seemed that this was being done to build his stature among Sikhs and instil fear in the minds of Hindus in Delhi.

By the end of that month the situation in Punjab had deteriorated to such an extent that parliament passed a resolution expressing 'deep anguish and concern'. Participating in the debate in the Rajya Sabha, Sikh member and senior leader of the CPI(M), Harkishan Singh Surjeet, accused the Congress of organizing Bhindranwale's visit to Delhi. 'I want to tell the House that he [Bhindranwale] gets protection from both the Akali Dal and the Congress ... I want to tell